CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

THE LEGACY GUARDIAN

In Search of an Anchor

After Mistry was replaced by Ratan, who became the interim chairman in October 2016, Tata Sons issued a statement announcing that in four months, a new chairman would be appointed to head the holding company. A five-member search committee was constituted to recommend a new head for Tata Sons and this time, Ratan ensured he was part of it. The others were Venu Srinivasan, Amit Chandra, Lord Kumar Bhattacharyya and Ronen Sen.

It all began very quietly for Chandrasekaran. A day after Cyrus was replaced, Ralf Speth, chairperson of TVS Motors, and Chandrasekaran were appointed to the board of Tata Sons. Chandrasekaran says that his appointment came after he received a call from Ratan while he was in Australia inquiring if he would join the board.

To many, it looked that the top job would go to an 'insider'. 'Everything is moving to the digital world, and we need a person who can lead us into this new age,' said Ishaat Hussain in an interview. And who better than the soft-spoken Chandrasekaran, with proven capabilities and an impeccable reputation for honesty and integrity, who had steered TCS on a sharp upward trajectory?

None could, however, read Ratan's mind. He kept his cards close to his chest as he quietly assessed Chandrasekaran's qualities, just as JRD had done his. And when he did, much emerged in Chandrasekaran's favour. Just as JRD had found many important similarities between Ratan and him, there were many things common between Ratan and Chandrasekaran.

Chandrasekaran is a quiet fighter like Ratan. Combating adversity is a part of his character. When, at the age of forty-four, he discovered that he